

Mother Superior

Because she is on the verge of doing what no other politician could since 1996: get the Women's Reservation Bill passed in Parliament, uniting parties across the political spectrum.

Because when she attaches 'personal importance' to something, whether it is the Women's Reservation Bill or the Right to Information Act, the entire Cabinet scurries to push it through, putting other governance issues on the backburner.

Because her chosen ones always deliver on their promise, whether it is her candidate for prime minister or her heir apparent.

Because she is on the verge of fulfilling a promise she made to herself in 1998 when she plunged into politics—to restore the party she inherited by marriage to its old glory.

Because she controls 207 Lok Sabha MPs and 71 Rajya Sabha MPs, as well as 11 states.

Because she remains the most powerful politician in the country today.

Favourite governance phrase Rajiv Gandhi's vision.

The reading list *The Lost Symbol* by Dan Brown; *Indira Gandhi: In the Crucible of Leadership* by Mary Carras; *Where Nothing Happens* by Padmanabha Pillai.

Her think tank Since social welfare is a prime concern, tends to listen to NGOs more than party MPs.

The moot point Women's Reservation Bill is to her what the nuclear deal was for Manmohan Singh. And if this mortgages the Government, 'so be it'.

POWER MATHS Ranked 13 in the *Forbes* List of 100 Most Powerful Women in 2009. Had slipped to number 21 in 2008.

QUIET VICTORY E-2009 was the first general election where her foreign origin was not an issue.



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RAHUL GANDHI

39. Congress General Secretary (2)

Prince of Combat

Because he is credited with the stunning Congress win in E-2009 where he was the party's star campaigner, addressing 102 meetings in 97 constituencies in 35 days.

Because there are few people who doubt that some day he will become the prime minister.

Because when Congressmen go to Sonia with a problem, quite often they are told "Ask Rahul".

Because the Congress, that earlier saw him only as a token dynast, now believes that he can save the party.

Because when he takes a suburban train, it becomes a nationwide spectacle sport.

Because whether it is asking for a relief package for Bundelkhand or for a rollback on the controversial sugarcane ordinance, the prime minister never says no.

The smart move Stops at an ATM during a high-risk visit to Mumbai just to show that he can.

New acquisition A designer stubble and a friendship band tied by a young cousin from his mother's side.

The Gandhian credo Has forged a new political ethic, with the BJP copying his tribal and Dalit dinner diplomacy.

The Tour de Force During his discovery of India tours, he listens more than he talks—hands behind his back, head down, looking up briefly just to ask a quick question.

POWER STATEMENT By refusing a Cabinet berth, he plays the classic outsider and hijacks the Opposition space.

WORKOUT MANTRA Does an hour of cardio followed by 40 minutes of weights at the five-star gym Amatra whenever he is in town.